

Episode 112: New Year Special Edition – *STRONG WORLD ONE PIECE FILM* Notes (Middle Part... Actually Part 1 Part 2)

Yesterday in Tokyo, we had the first snow of winter dancing down. First snow. In Oizumi it started snowing around noon and was coming down nicely for a while, but unfortunately it quickly turned to rain.

In the distant past when I was a student, there was the "Joint First-Stage University Examination" for national and public universities every January 15th (ah, that's what's now called the "Centre Test"), and mysteriously it would always snow on that day without fail. January 15th was "Coming of Age Day" anyway. Every year without fail, footage of people heading to exam venues in the snow and footage of 20-year-olds in ceremonial dress walking to coming-of-age ceremonies while minding their kimono hems in the snow would flow from the news—that was the standard.

When was the last time we had "heavy snow"?

Tokyo rarely gets snow in recent years. There are definitely quite a few Tokyo residents thinking "I wish we'd get enough snow to stop the trains once or twice a winter" (laugh). I wonder how it'll be? Will this winter bring that kind of heavy snow to Tokyo?
Now then.

Continuing "*STRONG WORLD ONE PIECE FILM* notes."

I sent the first batch of character colour samples to original creator Oda-san and waited several days. The long-awaited response came back. However, it wasn't a particularly favourable response.

There weren't any particular comments about the base colours I'd created—Robin with bright skin and Nami with light hair colour seemed "OK"—but the costume colours were

apparently lacking somehow. "The excitement doesn't come through"—I believe that was the comment.

The colours I'd conceived and built up had shifted somewhat toward a realistic direction in their coordination, and in addition to aiming too much for the original colour illustrations' atmosphere, from the director's word "transparency," I'd made the colours overall too light. That seemed to be the problem. The colours themselves probably lacked a bit of "powerful projection" or "volume." Looking back, there are several things that make me think "Yeah, that's right..."

And then, that unique "Oda World."

Everyone has their own colour worldview—especially creators, the original authors of popular manga. The person who created the characters and story naturally has strong visual images in their head. Frustrating as it is, it can't be surpassed. I was the one who couldn't show Oda-san something that would make him "grin."

And then...

"This might be very rude to Tsujita-san, but..." Oda-sensei said, "This time, I'd like to have input on every part I can possibly have input on..."

We ended up having to ask Oda-sensei to do the costume colour coordination concepts. Additional work amid his incredibly busy weekly serialisation schedule—I was full of apologetic feelings.

After waiting about three more weeks, it arrived from Oda-san—the raw manuscript of colour concepts. Character line art arranged in rows, with colours carefully placed using colour ink (I think?). Oda-san must have pondered various options too, because on top of the once-coloured versions, 2-3 alternative options per character were overlaid and pasted, neatly organised so the first choice was on top.

Facing those colour concepts, Director Sakai and I groaned. Wow, it was truly Oda World!

"Well, this is really a colour world that only the original creator could produce," Director Sakai and I said. Oda-san's colour proposals were bolder than any combination we'd thought of, and they fit the characters perfectly. It was frustratingly good (laugh). These were truly colour coordinations and combinations that only the original creator could produce.

Thus character colour creation resumed. Based on this first proposal from Oda-san, I repainted the colour samples. Golden Lion Shiki and Luffy's group costumes were mostly Oda-san's proposals, but still, for several characters including Golden Lion's subordinates Dr. Indigo and Captain Scarlett, Oda-san had coloured them exactly as I'd proposed. So these remained basically as-is.

I lined up the newly painted characters on the monitor again and adjusted the colour volume balance between characters. Once everything was roughly in order, after director approval, I sent them back to Oda-san for checking again.

However, at this point, we were right up against the "preview trailer" production deadline... The character designs themselves weren't changing, so animation work could proceed, but without finalised colours, colour direction (色指定) couldn't be done. Without colours, naturally the trailer couldn't be made. But the deadline was also tight. This was something that absolutely couldn't be helped. We couldn't wait for Oda-san's OK before applying colours...

But even for a trailer, fans are waiting to see it, and this would be their first moving visual, so we absolutely couldn't put out something half-hearted. "While movement and poses are important in footage, first impressions are overwhelmingly determined by

'colour'"—this is one of my theories, but colour's impact on impressions is very significant.

So we proceeded with trailer production and work while waiting for Oda-san's response. I created trailer colour direction based on the colours I'd sent to Oda-san for checking and proceeded with cut-by-cut colour direction. We'd push the work forward anyway, and if Oda-san gave his OK, we'd continue as-is. If retakes or changes came back, we'd respond to make the deadline somehow—that was the strategy.

Eventually, painted trailer cuts came back to me one after another. Naturally all cuts selected from the main feature storyboard. Since they'd basically be used in the main feature as is, the animation volume and impact looked good. These could be projected on screen with confidence.

And finally, Oda-san's response arrived. An "OK"!

Thus that trailer was completed. "Ah, finally we can stand at the starting point for *STRONG WORLD*"—that was my feeling.

(10.01.05)